DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Does Our Family Shape Our Lot in Life?

Derech Hashem 2:3:5-7

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 3, paragraphs 5-7 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 24 May 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: why the righteous suffer

The chapter on personal providence keeps adding explanations for why the righteous may suffer and the wicked prosper. The Rabbi reviewed them:

1. From the previous chapter: suffering that cleanses (yissurin shel meruk), and worldly reward that repays the wicked.
2. People must be in different states for there to be free choice, and each has a role, like the servant who pours the king's wine and the one who takes out the rubbish.
3. A person's actions bring consequences: someone with great goals but no means may be given blessing to reach perfection, as in Behukkotai, while a rasha may be given success that closes the door on him, or difficulty that stops him.

Paragraph 5: suffering to awaken

The Rabbi corrected himself that this was paragraph 5. From the same root, that Hashem wants the saddik to reach perfection, comes another explanation. A righteous person may have some sins, or an ordinary person's deeds may be evenly balanced, and he needs something to stir him to teshuvah. So he is given suffering from heaven so that he will examine his deeds.

These are not the sufferings of atonement from Chapter 2, whose purpose is to cleanse and refine. These are sufferings of awakening, so that you do teshuvah. "You could be the worst person and the worst punishments awaiting you. You do teshuvah, there's no punishment." Hashem really wants you to return, so that no punishment is needed. So there are stages: do not sin; if you sinned, do teshuvah; if you have not, Hashem first tries to awaken you with light sufferings; and only if you still do not wake up does the suffering of cleansing come. Hashem "opens their ear to musar" and says, "Return from iniquity," for your own benefit.

The Rabbi brought a saying attributed to Rabbi Yonatan Eybeschutz: you do not do CPR on someone who is dead. But when a person is alive and unconscious, you work to wake him up. So too, when Hashem sees potential in someone, He wakes him, to make sure he does not die from his sins. "You veered off slightly over the last few months. Let me bring you back on path."

Something small happens in the house, someone falls ill: "Are you willing to hear the message or not?"

This fourth reason explains why the righteous may suffer, but not why they prosper. "Not every explanation works" for every case.

Paragraph 6: the measure is filled

Last week we learned that Hashem sometimes gives the rasha time to sin and even helps him: "You want to go down this path? I'll provide you everything you want." But do not think there is no end to it. There is a limit to how long one can keep choosing evil. When that boundary is reached, there is no more patience: the measure is full, and he is destroyed. Until then he may even prosper, for the reasons explained, which allow him to continue his path.

"There reaches a point where: until here." Hashem can no longer tolerate it, sees no light and no chance of change, and "draws the curtains" on the person's life.

Questions from the group. - A participant asked: if the rasha is cut off suddenly when his measure is full, when are his Olam HaZeh misvot repaid? Must Hashem time it so that the moment he overflows, every misvah has been paid? The Rabbi acknowledged it is a difficult point, and a participant suggested his life might be extended just enough to repay them. The Rabbi's answer was that we cannot think the way Hashem thinks. - Do different people have different limits? "Of course, it will be dependent on you, on your makeup."

Paragraph 7: not in a vacuum

Hashem does not judge a person in a vacuum. Before reading the paragraph, the Rabbi explained one aspect of it: Hashem takes into account those before you, your ancestors (with less influence the further back they are), and those after you, your descendants. Suppose a man's measure is full and he must die now. But he has a child: who will look after him? Why should the child suffer? Hashem takes the whole picture into account, and one generation on, this man's grandchild might be a truly good person.

Where is this in the Humash? When Moshe saw the Egyptian striking a Hebrew, "he turned this way and that, and saw that there was no man." Hazal explain that he saw that no righteous person would come from him; only then could he act. "You deserve death for what you did, but I can't just look at you. I'm taking into account who your children are."

The Ramhal says that in the end providence weighs every detail as part of the whole structure: what came before you, what comes after you, and also sideways, your friends, community and town. If your death would make others suffer, that too must be weighed.

The Rabbi's correction: your lot in this world

The Rabbi then said he had explained the paragraph slightly wrongly. What he said is true, and the Ramhal will say it later, but here the point is narrower. Ancestors and descendants are taken into account in determining your portion in this world, not your reward in the World to Come. You do not get a higher place in the World to Come because your father was great.

A child can, however, raise a parent's place: the Gemara says a wise son brings merit to his father. That is not because any good a child does is automatically credited, but because the

parent created such a child. The same applies to doing things for the elevation of a soul (le-iluy nishmat). "People think it's just some mystical thing." It is simple: if twenty people make a berakhah because of someone who died, that person has left a positive impact, people who care about him and recognise Hashem because of him. "That shows something about you. That's how it works. Nothing more than that."

What parents give their children

After the brackets, the Ramhal says that if greatness and wealth were decreed for a person, his children will also be wealthy, and if they continue on the right path, they stay wealthy unless there is a reason to take it away. A twenty-year-old living comfortably only because of his parents: that is his starting portion.

The Rabbi cited the teaching that a father bestows five things on his son: wealth, beauty, strength (perhaps also determination), wisdom, and years. He admitted he did not fully understand the last, and noted that each is one variable among many. The default is that if nothing changes, you have roughly the life your parents had. "This isn't reward. Don't make a mistake." You were born handsome because your father was. If you go wrong, it may change.

Another way is zekhut avot, the merit of the fathers: sometimes something good suddenly happens to you because of your father. It works the other way too: you may be born poor because your parents were, and then change your situation.

Is this an answer to why the righteous suffer and the wicked prosper? "Not really," said the Rabbi. It explains your starting point in this world. Two or three more reasons were still to come, and the Ramhal would summarise them at the end of the chapter.

Summary

- Some suffering is meant to awaken a person to teshuvah before any suffering of cleansing is needed.
- Hashem gives the wicked time, but once the measure is full, the end comes.
- Hashem never judges a person in a vacuum: parents, children and community are all weighed.
- Ancestors and descendants shape our portion in this world, not our reward in the World to Come, though a good child reflects well on the parent.
- Parents pass on wealth, beauty, strength, wisdom and years as a starting point, which a person can then change.

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